Green Chile Chicken Tinga Enchiladas

Ingredients

Anaheim chiles . . . . . 18 oz.
Poblano chiles . . . . . 6 oz.
Jalapeño 1
Tomatillos, canned . . . . . 1 (28 oz.) can
White onions, medium (divided) 2
Garlic cloves 4
Vegetable oil, divided . . . . . 1/2 cup
Ground cumin . . . . . 1 1/2 tsp.
Mexican oregano . . . . . 1 tsp.
Kosher salt . . . . . to taste
Lime 1
Salted butter . . . . . 3 Tbsp.
All-purpose flour . . . . . 3 Tbsp.
Chicken broth . . . . . 1 cup
Mexican crema . . . . . 1/2 cup
Monterey Jack cheese, shredded . . 10 oz.
Cotija cheese . . . . . 3 oz.
Chicken tinga . . . . . 3 cups
Corn kernels . . . . . 1 cup
Fresh cilantro, chopped . . . . . 1/4 cup
Corn tortillas (6-inch) 12

Charred Chiles

Heat the air fryer to *400°F*

1. Rub the **Anaheim chiles**, the **poblano chiles**, and the **jalapeño** with about 1 tsp. of the **vegetable oil**. Cook them in a single layer at *400°F* for *15 minutes*, turning at *7 minutes*. They are done when the skins are blistered and blackened in patches and the flesh collapses under a gentle press. Pull the **jalapeño** as soon as it is soft. Continue in *2–3 minute* passes for any chile that is still firm.
2. Cook a second batch the same way for any chiles that did not fit in the first layer.
3. When the chiles are cool enough to handle, slit each one and scrape out the seeds. Leave the charred skins on. Add them to the blender.

Green Sauce

While the chiles cook — Drain the **tomatillos** and discard the liquid; put the fruit in the blender — Dice the **white onions**; put 1/2 cup in *Large Bowl #2* (filling) and the rest in the blender — Peel the **garlic** and add it to the blender — Combine 1 1/2 tsp. **cumin** and 1 tsp. **Mexican oregano** in *Small Bowl #1* (sauce spices) — Juice the **lime** into *Small Bowl #2*

1. Blend the chiles, **tomatillos**, **white onion**, and **garlic** until the puree is smooth and no papery skin remains, about *45–90 seconds*. Scrape the blender and blend for another *20–30 seconds* if flakes remain. Add a spoonful of water only if the blades stall.

2. Set a large saucepan over medium heat. Add 2 Tbsp. **vegetable oil** and heat until it shimmers. Stir in the **cumin** and **Mexican oregano** (*Small Bowl #1*) for *30 seconds*, until the raw spice smell turns fragrant. Pour in the puree. It will sputter. Stir until it settles, and scrape the bottom clean.

3. Leave the pot at a steady medium simmer. Char the **corn** in the next step, then stir the sauce again. Keep simmering, stirring often, for *15–25 minutes* in all, until the color has darkened, the raw onion edge is gone, and a finger path through the sauce on a spoon stays open. The surface looks glossy, and the spoon still moves through the pot. Continue for *3–5 minutes* if it still tastes sharp or runs thin.

4. While the sauce simmers, pat the **corn** dry. Heat a 12-inch skillet over medium-high heat. Cook the **corn** in the dry skillet, stirring, for *6–10 minutes*, until the moisture cooks off, the pan looks dry, and the kernels are spotted deep brown and smell toasted. Continue for *2 minutes* if the pan is still steaming or the kernels are pale. Add the **corn** to *Large Bowl #2*.

5. Take the sauce off the heat. Stir in the **lime juice** (*Small Bowl #2*) and 1 1/2 tsp. **kosher salt**. Taste, and add more **kosher salt** if it tastes flat. Scrape the sauce into *Large Bowl #1*. There should be about 5 cups. Measure 2 cups for the creamy sauce and leave the rest in the bowl. That remainder, about 3 cups, is the sauce to keep.

Creamy Enchilada Sauce

Shred the **Monterey Jack**; set aside in *Medium Bowl #1*

1. Set the empty saucepan over medium heat. Melt 3 Tbsp. **salted butter**. Whisk in 3 Tbsp. **flour** and cook for *1–2 minutes*, until the roux smells toasty and looks pale tan. Keep it pale. A darker roux tastes bitter here.
2. Whisk in 1 cup **chicken broth** a little at a time. Simmer for *2–3 minutes*, whisking, until the sauce is thick, smooth, and heavy on a spoon. It will look pasty.
3. Whisk in 2 cups of the green sauce from *Large Bowl #1*. Simmer for *3–5 minutes*, until the sauce is one color, glossy, and a finger path clears slowly. It should pour. Simmer for *2 minutes* more if it looks thin, or loosen it with a splash of water if the spoon stands up in it.
4. Take the pot off the heat. Stir a few tablespoons of the hot sauce into the **Mexican crema**, then stir the **crema** back into the pot. Add 1 cup of the **Monterey Jack** (*Medium Bowl #1*) and stir until the shreds disappear and the sauce is smooth. Set the pot over low heat for *1 minute* if the cheese will not melt. Keep it below a simmer. Taste. Add **kosher salt** only if it tastes flat.

Filling

Chop the **cilantro**; add 2 Tbsp. to *Large Bowl #2* and set the rest aside in *Small Bowl #3* (garnish) — Have the **chicken tinga** ready

1. Add 3 cups **chicken tinga** and 1 cup of the **Monterey Jack** (*Medium Bowl #1*) to *Large Bowl #2*, with the diced **white onion**, the charred **corn**, and the 2 Tbsp. **cilantro** already there. Fold in 2–3 Tbsp. of the plain green sauce from *Large Bowl #1*. The meat should look moist and coated. Add another spoonful of green sauce if the **tinga** looks dry. Taste, and add **kosher salt** only if it tastes flat.

Enchiladas

Heat the oven to *375°F* — Crumble the **cotija** into *Small Bowl #3*, with the remaining **cilantro**

1. Spread about ¾ cup of the creamy sauce in a 9 inch×13 inch baking dish. Pour about 1 cup more into a shallow bowl for dipping. Leave the rest in the saucepan.
2. While the oven heats, set the skillet over medium heat. Add the remaining **vegetable oil** and heat until it shimmers. Fry the **tortillas** one at a time for *5–10 seconds* per side, until they soften, blister slightly, and bend without cracking. Drain them and stack them in a towel. Continue for a few seconds per side if a tortilla still cracks. Add a spoonful of **oil** if the skillet goes dry.
3. Dip each **tortilla** in the creamy sauce, let the excess drip off, and spoon about 3 Tbsp. of the filling (*Large Bowl #2*) down the center. Roll it closed and set it seam-side down in the dish. Pack the rolls so they hold each other shut. Extra filling keeps for another meal.
4. Pour the remaining creamy sauce over the enchiladas, including any sauce left in the dipping bowl. Scatter about ½ cup of the **Monterey Jack** (*Medium Bowl #1*) over the top. Cover with foil.
5. Bake at *375°F*, covered, for *15 minutes* when the filling went in warm, or *25 minutes* when it was cold from the refrigerator.
6. Uncover and bake until the **Monterey Jack** is melted, the sauce bubbles at the edges, and the center of the dish reads *165°F*, about *8–12 minutes* more. Continue in *3 minute* increments until the center is hot and the edges are bubbling.
7. Rest for *5 minutes*. Scatter the **cotija** and the remaining **cilantro** (*Small Bowl #3*) over the top. The enchiladas are at their best in the next half hour. The plain green sauce in *Large Bowl #1* is the batch to keep.

Equipment Required

- Air fryer
- Blender
- Large saucepan, 3- to 4-quart
- 12-inch skillet
- 9 inch×13 inch baking dish
- Shallow bowl or pie plate, for dipping
- Colander
- Whisk
- Tongs
- Wooden spoon or spatula
- Cutting board
- Chef's knife
- Measuring cups and spoons
- Can opener
- Small prep bowls (3)
- Medium prep bowl (1)
- Large prep bowls (2)
- Instant-read thermometer
- Aluminum foil

Hints and Notes

Yield

- Makes 12 enchiladas in a 9 inch×13 inch dish. Serves 4–6.
- The green sauce yields about 5 cups after it coats a spoon. The enchiladas use 2 cups. About 3 cups remain for later. A looser simmer leaves more. A longer simmer leaves less.

Mise en Place

- Small Bowl #1 — sauce spices: 1½ tsp. **cumin**, 1 tsp. **Mexican oregano**
- Small Bowl #2 — juice of 1 **lime**
- Small Bowl #3 — garnish: remaining **cilantro**, then the crumbled **cotija** (3 oz.)
- Medium Bowl #1 — shredded **Monterey Jack** (10 oz., about 2½ cups)
- Large Bowl #1 — finished plain green sauce; 2 cups go into the creamy sauce, and the rest stays here
- Large Bowl #2 — filling: ½ cup diced **white onion**, then the charred **corn**, then **chicken tinga**, 1 cup **Monterey Jack**, and 2 Tbsp. **cilantro**
- Blender — drained **tomatillos**, most of the **onion**, and the peeled **garlic**, then the seeded chiles
- Prep the green sauce while the chiles air-fry. Char the **corn** while the green sauce simmers. Fry the **tortillas** while the oven heats.

Ingredient Tips

- **Anaheim chiles** and **poblano chiles**: weigh them. 18 oz. of Anaheim to 6 oz. of poblano is 3:1. That is about 5–6 Anaheim and 1–2 poblano. Anaheim carries the green-chile flavor. Poblano adds body and sweetness.
- **Jalapeño**: one pepper, seeds scraped out after cooking. It warms the sauce. The chipotle in the **chicken tinga** is the main heat.
- **Tomatillos**: one 28 oz. can, drained, liquid discarded. They go into the blender as they are. The simmer is what concentrates them.
- **White onions**: two medium onions. ½ cup stays raw in the filling. The rest is blended into the sauce. A medium onion is about 1–1½ cups diced, so the sauce gets a generous amount.

- **Chicken tinga**: use the tinga in this book. Measure 3 cups of the sauced, shredded meat. One batch is more than this pan needs.
- **Salted butter**: it seasons the creamy sauce. Taste before adding more salt.
- **Chicken broth**: low-sodium. The green sauce, the butter, and the cheese already carry salt.
- **Mexican crema**: sour cream works in its place. Temper either one so it stays smooth.
- **Monterey Jack**: 10 oz. is about 2½ cups shredded. 1 cup melts into the creamy sauce, 1 cup goes into the filling, and about ½ cup melts on top in the oven.
- **Cotija**: 3 oz., crumbled. It stays salty and dry. Scatter it on after the rest so it does not melt into the **Jack**.
- **Corn tortillas**: six-inch corn tortillas. Ones a day old fry and roll with less breaking.
- **Corn kernels**: fresh or frozen. Pat them dry so they brown after the moisture cooks off.

Preparation Tips

- Keep the chiles in one layer. Overlap softens them with steam, and the skins stay pale.
- The charred skins stay on. Blend until the flakes are gone. Those skins are the roast in this sauce.
- The green puree is thick and will scorch if it sits. Scrape the bottom before you leave it to char the **corn**, then stir it again as soon as the **corn** is done.
- After the broth goes into the roux, the sauce looks heavy. The 2 cups of green sauce are what bring it back to a pourable coat.
- Stir the **crema** in off the heat. A boil can make it look grainy. Low heat melts the **Jack** without splitting the sauce.
- Fry the **tortillas** only until they bend. A crisp tortilla cracks when it is rolled. The measured **oil** covers the chiles, the simmer, and the skillet. Keep a little more nearby if the skillet goes dry.
- Fill with about 3 Tbsp. A packed tortilla splits. Extra filling keeps for another meal.
- Cold **tinga** needs the longer covered bake so the center reaches *165°F*. Warm **tinga** is ready on the shorter time.
- **Cotija** goes on after the *5 minute* rest. Under the foil it softens into the melted **Jack**.

Make Ahead & Storage

- The plain green sauce is the part to save. Cool it, then refrigerate up to *4 days* or freeze up to *3 months*. Thaw overnight in the refrigerator.
- Reheat the plain sauce over low heat. Add a splash of water if it has tightened.
- Make the green sauce ahead, then build the creamy sauce on the day you bake. The creamy sauce is best the day it is made.
- Baked enchiladas keep up to *4 days* in the refrigerator. Reheat, covered, at *350°F* until the center reads *165°F*.
- Add the **cilantro** and **cotija** after reheating.
- The enchiladas are at their best in the half hour after the *5 minute* rest.

Serving Suggestions

- Serve with Mexican rice and beans, diced **white onion**, and a squeeze of **lime**.
- Keep the plain green sauce for eggs, pork, chicken, rice, or another pan of enchiladas.
- A Mexican lager or a hibiscus agua fresca stands up to the chile and the crema.